Apple TV+

Product Teardown: User Journey

Understanding Apple TV+ as a Business

Before diagnosing the problems, it helps to understand what Apple TV+ is actually optimized for because the product's strategy drives many of its design choices. It matters for understanding Apple TV+, as it is not competing with Netflix or Prime on subscriber count but for ecosystem stickiness, Apple One bundle value and brand prestige. (For context, the Apple One bundle involves iCloud, Apple TV+, Apple Music and Apple Arcade.)

The core strategic purpose of Apple TV+

What Apple TV+ is built for	**Metrics and Goals to be aware of**
Keep Apple device users inside the ecosystem	*Retention metrics matter more than raw subscriber numbers*
Drive value for the Apple One bundle	*Engagement depth matters more than standalone subscription growth*
Build prestige brand through award winning originals	*Quality of content prioritised over catalogue breadth*
Recurring subscription revenue at high margins	*Churn prevention is a high-priority business objective*

As of late 2025, the platform has around 45 million subscribers globally. For context, Netflix has approximately 300 million paid subscribers and Amazon Prime has around 200 million.From what I understand, Apple TV+ is not trying to match that number , it is trying to serve the 2+ billion people already inside the Apple ecosystem.

My objective was to understand the user journey, gain insights into the platform's goals and identify opportunities for improvement. These observations are based solely on my experience as a user.

The Funnel

STAGE 1

Discovery & Sign-up

User hears about Apple TV+, evaluates the service and decides to start a trial

What happens here

A user discovers Apple TV+ through a new iPhone/Mac device prompt, word of mouth about a specific show or advertising. They land on the Apple TV+ page and must answer a single question: "Is there enough content here for ₹99/month " Apple wins this moment only on original content.

Where users drop off

- User visits the page, sees a grid of unfamiliar titles and exits without signing up
- Users compare the catalogue against Netflix or Prime and perceive the library as too small for the price
- User signs up specifically for one show, watches it, has nothing else lined up

Root causes

The homepage grid is the wrong format for a thin catalogue

Apple TV+ currently has over 100 original series and films, a significant expansion from its 2019 launch with 7 originals and growing. But the browse grid still surfaces this as a list. Netflix conceals its quantity advantage with algorithmic rows, genres and moods. Apple's homepage has not solved the "this looks small" perception problem.

Social proof is absent at the awareness stage

Severance holds a 95% Rotten Tomatoes score. Slow Horses has won multiple BAFTAs. In 2024 alone, Apple TV+ shows won 9 Primetime Emmy Awards. None of this surfaces visibly before sign-up. Apple leads with beautiful aesthetics (full-screen trailers) but withholds the third-party validation signals that convert skeptical visitors

STAGE 2

First Launch & Onboarding

User opens Apple TV+ for the first time and gets to 'first content played' — the single most important event in the funnel

What happens here

The user has signed up. The product must deliver its first value moment within minutes, ideally within the first session. For streaming, the 'aha moment' is the first emotional hook in the first piece of content. Everything before that is friction. The critical question the product must answer immediately: 'What should I watch first?'

Where users drop off

- User opens the app, sees the hero banner auto-playing a trailer, feels overwhelmed by an unfamiliar catalogue, closes the app without playing anything
- User starts a show, watches 8–10 minutes, doesn't feel hooked, exits and never comes back
- User came specifically for one show, watches it, now has nothing next because the recommendation engine hasn't learned enough about them

Root causes

Apple TV+ does zero taste profiling at onboarding

Netflix asks you to pick 3 shows you like before your first browse. Apple TV+ drops you on a generic home screen with no personalisation signal. The first content recommendation defaults to showing the most-watched shows regardless of whether they match the new user. A user who dislikes workplace drama will be shown Severance and might leave immediately

STAGE 5

Player Experience

Trying to control playback speed. User is watching content and looks for a way to adjust how fast the show plays, a feature they use on most other platform

What happens here

The user is mid-episode and wants to speed things up , maybe it's a slow-burn episode, they are rewatching something or they just have thirty minutes and want to get through more. They tap the screen to bring up the player controls. Audio options are there. Subtitle preferences are there. But there's no speed option. Every other platform they use daily , Netflix, YouTube has this. Apple TV+ doesn't.
What makes it more noticeable is that the player controls are otherwise clean and well-designed. It's clearly not an oversight in terms of effort ; Apple has put thought into the player. Which makes the absence of speed control feel more like a deliberate decision.

Root causes

A deliberate product choice, not an oversight

Apple has historically resisted playback speed controls,out of respect for the creators and directors of its original content, the idea being that the intended pace is part of the artistic experience. This is consistent with how Apple approaches its originals, as prestige television, not content to be consumed as fast as possible. Whether that's the right call is debatable, but it explains why the feature hasn't appeared despite being standard everywhere else.

The user base has changed

Playback speed control used to feel like a podcast or lecture feature. Now it's mainstream, a significant portion of regular Netflix and Prime users routinely watch at 1.25x or 1.5x. The habit formed on other platforms carries over, and when Apple TV+ doesn't support it, the platform feels one step behind rather than intentionally restrained.

STAGE 4

Content Discovery

User finishes their first show and must find a second title, this moment determines trial-to-paid conversion

What happens here

A user who finishes their first show and immediately finds a second is highly likely to convert to paid. A user who finishes and cannot find what to watch next will let the trial lapse. The catalogue constraint problem becomes acutely real here, not at sign-up.

Where users drop off

- User finishes Severance season finale , high emotional moment, returns to home screen which shows the same generic layout.
- User searches for a specific genre (true crime, documentary) catalogue is thin in that genre , user opens another streaming app and doesn't return
- User finishes all available episodes of a weekly show and has nothing to watch while waiting for the next episode

Root causes

The end-of-show screen is a dead end

When a user finishes a season finale, Apple shows a rating prompt and returns to the title page, no persuasive forward momentum. Netflix shows 'Because you watched X' with immediate autoplay previews. The moment of

highest emotional engagement after finishing a great show is wasted. There is no ambient recommendation waiting to inherit the user's attention.

Genre and mood filtering is surface-level

Apple TV+ browse is structured around editorial labels like 'Critically Acclaimed' and 'For the Family'. These are content-type categories, not mood or feel filters. A user in a specific mood (tense thriller / feel-good comedy / mind-bending mystery) cannot filter to that mood.

STAGE 5

Ongoing Engagement

Paid subscriber in months 1–3, is the product becoming a habit or just a line item they'll cut next billing cycle?

What happens here

The user is now a paying subscriber. The question is whether Apple TV+ becomes a genuine weekly habit or sits dormant between flagship releases. A subscriber who opens the app fewer than twice per week in their first 3 months is a high churn risk at the next content gap.

Where users drop off here

- Subscriber opens app 1–2x per week but spends most time browsing without playing, dissatisfaction leads to cancellation.
- No social layer means users miss the cultural conversation happening around shows, reducing urgency to open the app

Root causes

No social or community layer

Apple TV+ has no native social features. Watching Severance alone is enjoyable. Knowing millions of people are watching it and actively discussing Episode 5 creates urgency and community.

Apple TV+ has no passive retention mechanism

Netflix retains subscribers between active watches because people feel there's always more they haven't seen, the catalogue is so vast the FOMO is real. Apple TV+ has a focused catalogue of originals. A subscriber who has been on the platform for 6 months has likely seen everything they want to see. There is no content depth to fall back on between originals. No UX fix can fully solve this, it is a catalogue strategy problem.

Where We Should Start !

Introduce a short preference onboarding flow at first launch consisting of 2–3 questions about the user's preferred genres, content types or viewing interest like Pinterest's onboarding flow. Use these responses to personalize and reorder the home screen for the user's first session.

Success Metrics

- Time to First Play
- First-Episode Completion Rate
- 7-Day Retention Rate

Hypothesis
Reducing the effort required to discover relevant content will shorten the time-to-value from approximately 15 minutes to under 5 minutes. By presenting users with content that aligns with their interests from the outset, the platform can reduce decision paralysis, accelerate the user's first meaningful engagement and improve 7-day retention.

Conclusion

Apple TV+ is not designed to win streaming-first users away from other platforms.

It is designed to keep iPhone and Apple device users inside the Apple ecosystem, drive Apple One bundle value and build brand prestige through award-winning originals.

The product's retention problems are largely a consequence of a marketing strategy that is show-centric rather than platform-centric. Users are acquired because of Shows like Severance not because of 'Apple TV+ as a platform.' When the show ends, the platform has not built enough of its own identity to hold them.

The opportunity is not to out-catalogue Netflix. It is to ensure that every subscriber consistently finds something worth watching next, positioning Apple TV+ as the trusted destination for premium, thoughtfully curated storytelling that respects their time.